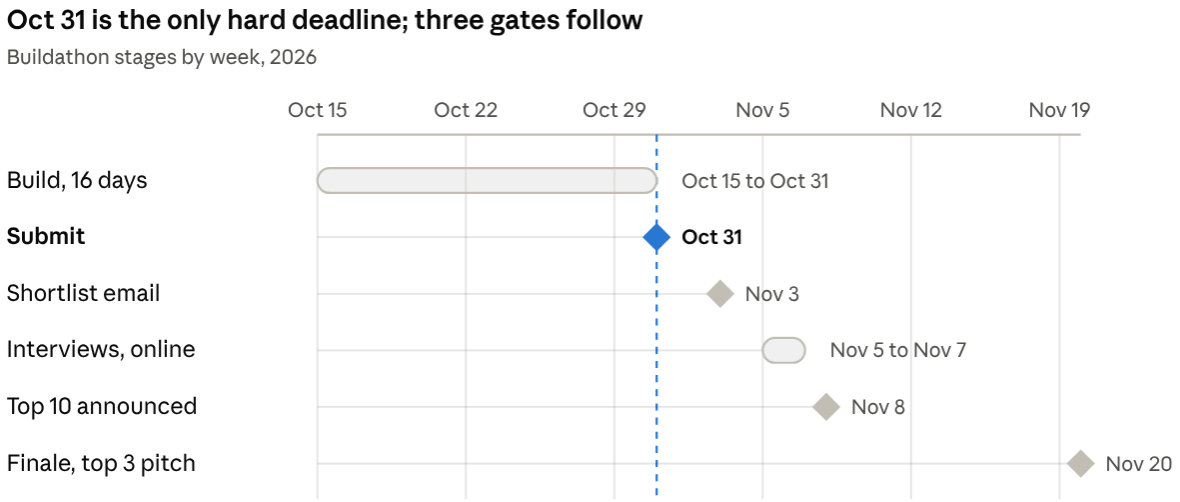
Bolna Buildathon: Research & Win Plan

Oct 15, 2026 · @Anudeep

The competition at a glance

A 16-day virtual build (Oct 15–31) judged in three rounds: a form-based shortlist, an online interview, and a live stage pitch. First place is the only prize that carries the YC interview with Grey Baker. Source: bolna.ai/symphony/buildathon.



buildathon timeline · Oct 15 to Nov 20, 2026

Everything before Nov 20 is online. Sixteen days of build, then three gates: a form shortlist, an online interview, and the live finale.

Item	Fact
Build window	Oct 15 – Oct 31, 2026. "Build something real with voice AI."
Submission deadline	Oct 31, 2026
Shortlist	Nov 3, 2026 — selected teams get an interview invite by email
Interviews	Nov 5, 2026 to Nov 7, online
Results	Nov 8, 2026 — top 10 are finalists and get free Symphony tickets

Item	Fact
Grand finale	Nov 20, 2026, Abhyas Hall (Grand Ballroom), The Lalit Ashok, Bengaluru. Top 3 pitch live to a ~1,000-person crowd. Travel covered.
1st place	₹50,000 + YC interview with Grey Baker (YC General Partner) + travel
2nd / 3rd	₹40,000 / ₹30,000 + goodies + travel + stage pitch
Format	Fully virtual until the finale. Teams of 1 to 4. Students, professionals, indie builders.
Tracks	None. "Build whatever you like, as long as voice is part of it." A new product or a voice feature on an existing one.
Bolna's own examples	A voice tutor for kids; a phone helpdesk for a local clinic; a voice layer on an app you already built; a hands-free tool for drivers or field workers
Credits	FAQ: "Yes. Every builder gets credits, provided by our sponsors." Amounts not published; claim via the Bolna Builders Slack.
Judging criteria	Not published anywhere. See "What actually wins" below.
Buildathon sponsors	Plivo, Exotel, Sarvam, Cartesia, Deepgram, Kalpa Labs. Co-branded Y Combinator × Bolna.

What you submit (form): team size, name, registered email, project name, a **project description of at most 200 characters** ("what it does and who it's for"), a **submission link** (GitHub repo, live app on Vercel etc., or demo), and a **pitch deck or pitch video** on Google Drive or Luma set to "Anyone with the link".

So the Nov 3 shortlist is decided from 200 characters, one link, and one deck or video. The interview decides the top 10. The stage decides the top 3.

Application form (apply now): team size, name, email, WhatsApp number, city, college or company, LinkedIn or GitHub, "Have you decided on your idea?", project name, "Since when have you been working on this idea?", and "What are you building, and where does voice AI come in?"

Who is in the room

No judges are named. The people who will plausibly score you are the Bolna team (shortlist and interview), and at the finale the Symphony speakers below, with Grey Baker as the only person whose verdict unlocks the YC interview. Source: Symphony speakers.

Grey Baker, YC General Partner (profile). Became a General Partner in June 2026 after several batches as a Visiting Partner. Co-founded Dependabot: built the MVP in two weeks on savings, got friends to try it, bootstrapped to $14k MRR, acquired by GitHub in 2019. Co-founded Pincites (YC S23, legal AI, acquired by Filevine). Employee #3 at GoCardless (YC S11), where he led product and engineering. MPhil Economics, Cambridge. Active angel. Has three children. Bias to expect: developer-minded, bootstrapper, "do things that don't scale", ship fast, charge early, know your numbers.

Bolna's founders (Maitreya Wagh, Prateek Sachan) were rejected by YC five times with the feedback "Indian enterprises are not going to pay." They got in (Fall 2025) once they showed $25k MRR from $100 pilots. 75% of their revenue is self-serve. Expect them to ask "who pays?" and to value real usage over polish.

Person	Role	Why it matters to you
Grey Baker	General Partner, Y Combinator	Interviews the winner. Only person who matters for the YC prize.
Akarsh Shrivastava	Partner, General Catalyst	Led Bolna's $6.3M seed. Likely finale judge.
Aarthi Ramamurthy	Founder & GP, Schema Ventures	Investor. Likely finale judge.
Prasanna Krishnamoorthy	Managing Partner, Upekkha	Indian B2B / vertical AI accelerator. Will probe business model.
Prashant Shishodia	CEO, Kalpa Labs (YC F25)	Sponsor. Speech-model founder; appreciates good use of TTS.
Venky Balasubramaniam	Co-founder & CEO, Plivo	Diamond sponsor. Telephony.
Sachin Bhatia	Co-founder, Exotel	Diamond sponsor. Indian telephony.
Sudarshan Kamath	CEO, Smallest.ai	Associate sponsor. TTS/STT.
Madhav Krishna	CEO, Vahan AI	Blue-collar hiring via voice. Do not build his product.

Person	Role	Why it matters to you
Anuja Dhawan	Founder Dubverse; AI Products at Exotel	Dubbing and telephony.
Tanuj Bhojwani	Former Head, People+AI (EkStep)	Public-interest voice AI (Bhashini world).
Dr. Manish Gupta	Senior Director, Google DeepMind	Technical depth. Google Cloud is Diamond sponsor.
Srinivas Narayanan	Former CTO B2B Apps, OpenAI	Technical depth.

Symphony sponsors (event page): Diamond: Google Cloud, Truecaller for Business, Exotel, Plivo. Gold: Kalpa Labs, Sarvam. Silver: Wispr Flow, Simplismart, Cartesia, Deepgram, Vobiz. Associates: Smallest.ai, Agnost AI. Also NVIDIA Inception and OpenAI. Expect 1,000+ attendees, 42+ speakers, 3 stages; the audience is "founders, investors, CXOs, engineering and product leaders, and operators building or backing Voice AI."

Tools and credits

You can build and run a 30-family pilot for roughly $150 of credits, most of which is free today. The one hard constraint is telephony: outbound calls to Indian mobiles work on day one, but receiving calls on an Indian number requires a registered company.

Bolna (pricing, FAQ, concurrency)

- Free: $5 signup credit. Trial accounts get 2 concurrent outbound calls and can only call verified numbers. Any top-up from $10 unlocks the paid tier: 10 concurrent calls, call anyone.
- Cost: about 6¢/min (≈₹5.5) flat for STT + LLM + TTS when you use "preferred models", plus telephony, plus a $0.02/min platform fee. Budget ₹6 to ₹8 per minute all-in for an Indian call. $100 buys roughly 1,200 to 1,600 minutes.
- Preferred models (stay on these to stay cheap). STT: Deepgram nova-3, Sarvam saaras:v4 and saarika:v2.5, Azure, ElevenLabs scribe_v2_realtime. LLM: gpt-5-mini, gpt-5.4-mini, gpt-4.1-mini, gpt-4o-mini. TTS: Sarvam bulbul:v2/v3/v4-flash, Cartesia sonic-3.x, ElevenLabs flash/turbo/multilingual_v2, Azure neural.
- Outbound to India works immediately: `POST /call` with an agent id and the recipient's number uses Bolna's shared +91 numbers. No number purchase, no KYC (making calls).
- Your own Indian number costs $5/month but needs a compliance application: CIN certificate and GST certificate, so a registered company. Inbound calls on an Indian number therefore need a company. 140/160-series numbers need DLT registration

(₹5,900); ignore for the buildathon. US numbers via Twilio are instant.

- Web Call SDK (`@bolna/web-call`, browser WebRTC): no telephony cost, perfect for a "talk to it now" button on your landing page and on stage. Enabled on request via Slack or support@bolna.ai. Request it on day one.
- Truecaller business caller ID on your own number: $20/month.
- Features worth showing the judges (changelog): graph agents with built-in testing; single-prompt multilingual agents that auto-switch language and can start a call in a chosen language; Sarvam Bulbul v4 Flash (Oct 15: 222 voices, 13 Hindi-English code-mixed); keyword biasing for Indian names and numbers; knowledge base (PDF/URL); custom function calling; web search during calls (Oct 8); Cal.com booking; call transfer; DTMF/IVR; voicemail detection; batches with scheduling, calling-hour guardrails and auto-retry; workflows (call, extraction, condition, WhatsApp via AiSensy); post-call extractions (structured fields, sentiment); webhooks; MCP server and Claude connector (Oct 9); CLI; Bolna Skills for Claude Code and Cursor. OpenAI Realtime and Gemini Live speech-to-speech are also supported.
- The open-source core (`bolna-ai/bolna`, MIT) is looking for maintainers. Use the hosted platform.

Sponsor free tiers (confirmed from their own pages; buildathon bonuses will come via Slack)

Vendor	Free today	Notes
Sarvam	₹100 (docs) or ₹1,000 (pricing page) on signup	Indic STT (saaras v4), TTS Bulbul v4 Flash, translation, Sarvam-M LLM. ₹30 per 10k chars TTS, ₹30 per hour STT. A Symphony ticket adds ₹2,500.
Deepgram	$200, no card, no expiry	Nova-3 streaming $0.0048/min; Aura-2 TTS; Voice Agent API. Separate startup program up to $100k.
Cartesia	20K credits/month (about 27 min TTS, 1h51m STT)	Pro $5/month: 100K credits plus instant voice cloning.
Kalpa Labs	Open beta; pricing not public	TTS inside Bolna since Sep 3. Ask in Slack; their CEO is a speaker.
Plivo	Trial calls only to sandboxed numbers; India numbers need business KYC	Use through Bolna, not directly.

Vendor	Free today	Notes
Exotel	₹500 credits, 7 days, KYC	Use through Bolna, not directly.
Google Cloud (Diamond)	Gemini API free tier	Gemini Live speech-to-speech works in Bolna.
OpenAI	Web Search tool in Bolna needs no key	gpt-5-mini is a preferred model.
Vercel	Hobby plan	Landing page, dashboard, webhook receiver.
Symphony registration	$100 Bolna credits + ₹2,500 Sarvam + 3 months Wispr Flow	Ticket price not published. Finalists (top 10) get tickets free.

Budget reality. 16 days of dev testing (about 300 min) plus a 30-user pilot at 5 min/day for 10 days (about 1,500 min) is roughly 1,800 minutes, or $110 to $150 on Bolna. Keep $50 to $100 of your own money ready so slow credit logistics never gate user testing.

Voice agents in India: the market and what they are used for

India's voice-agent market is small in revenue (about $150M in 2024, under $1B by 2030 on the most-cited estimate), huge in minutes (several vendors each claim a million or more calls a day), and dominated by outbound business calls for banks, lenders and e-commerce. Human telecallers at ₹5 to ₹8 per connected minute cap what anyone can charge, so the open ground is consumer-paid and inbound products, not another outbound sales bot.

Market size

Source	Scope	Figure
NextMSC via Caller Digital	India voice AI	$153M in 2024, $958M by 2030, 35.7% CAGR; the most-repeated anchor, from one research house
Grand View Research	India conversational AI	about $575M in 2025; voice is an estimated 25% to 40% of that

Source	Scope	Figure
Grand View Research	India AI agents, all kinds	$417M in 2025 to $15.2B by 2033 (57% CAGR); a second series on the same page says $0.28B in 2024 to $3.55B by 2030
MarketsandMarkets	India AI voice generation (TTS)	$131M in 2025 to $914M by 2030
Meticulous, SNS Insider	Global voice AI agents	$3.7B to $5.1B in 2026
The Hundred-Buyer Problem (investor analysis, Oct 2026)	Funding into Indian voice AI startups	$329M raised Jan to Aug 2026 versus $12.9M in the same months of 2025; about $449M cumulative across 31 companies, 20 with institutional backing
Same analysis	Revenue of named companies	Sarvam about $12M ARR; Yellow.ai $34M 2025 revenue; Exotel ₹490 crore FY25 revenue; Bolna about $700k ARR; Ringg AI $15.5M raised

The same analysis does the bottom-up: roughly 100 Indian enterprises pay six-figure-dollar contracts, each keeps two to five vendors on its panel, pilots are $20,000 to $30,000 and good annual contracts $100,000 to $500,000, so the enterprise pool is about $30M a year before it is split. The money is real; the margin, the author argues, belongs to buyers, telcos and model owners.

Who is building, by layer

Layer	Players	What to know
Speech models and infrastructure	Sarvam, Gnani, Smallest.ai, Navana, Shunya Labs, Reverie, Mihup, AI4Bharat (open source), Kalpa Labs; global: ElevenLabs, Deepgram, Cartesia, OpenAI Realtime, Gemini Live	Sarvam raised about $275M in total at a $1.5B valuation (June 2026, $150M from HCLTech). Gnani raised $10M (March 2026), reported 1 million calls a day in August 2025 and claims gross margin above 80% from owning its models. Navana raised about $5M (September 2026). Sarvam's Hindi word error rate is cited at 5.0% against 13.0% for Deepgram Nova-3; southern languages sit at 14% to 19%.
Agent and orchestration platforms	Bolna, Ringg AI, Blue Machines, Sarvam Samvaad, Smallest Atoms, Nurix, Vobiz, SuperBryn; global: Vapi, Retell, Bland, LiveKit, Pipecat	Bolna: $6.3M seed, 200,000 calls a day, 1,050+ paying customers, ₹5.5 a minute self-serve and ₹1.75 to ₹2 on enterprise commitments. Ringg: $15.5M raised, appointment booking across 1,200 Practo clinics, support for CRED, Groww and Flipkart.
BFSI vertical agents	GreyLabs, Arrowhead, Credgenics, Spocto, CoRover BharatGPT, Skit.ai	GreyLabs: ₹85 crore Series A (October 2025), 50+ BFSI clients including RBL, AU, IDFC First, Groww. Skit.ai claims over a billion conversations, mostly collections. BFSI is the only vertical with enough buyers to concentrate venture money.

Layer	Players	What to know
Incumbents, BPO-tech and CPaaS	Gnani, Skit, SquadStack, Convin, Yellow.ai, Jio Haptik, Uniphore, Kore.ai; telephony: Exotel, Ozonetel, MyOperator, Knowlarity, Airtel IQ, Tanla, Route Mobile, Plivo	SquadStack claims 5 million calls a day across 60+ brands and has moved to revenue-linked pricing. Exotel bought Cogno and Dubverse; Nurix merged with Verloop; Yellow.ai is buying BPOs; HCLTech backed Sarvam. Consolidation is under way.
In-house builders	NoBroker's ConvoZen, Meesho, Eternal (Nugget), Bajaj Finserv (FINAI), Swiggy with Sarvam	ConvoZen handles over 2 million conversations a day across 50+ enterprises (HDFC Bank, HDFC Life, Maruti, Spinny, Cars24); Meesho's bot handles 60,000 calls a day. Every in-house builder is one fewer buyer.
Vertical applications	Vahan.ai (blue-collar hiring), Edysor (admissions), KissanAI (agriculture), Vodex (US collections), Wysa (mental health), Pype AI (hospital front desk)	Thin layer; most are B2B.
Public infrastructure	Bhashini and VoicERA (MeitY, February 2026), MahaVISTAAR (Maharashtra, May 2025), AMUL's Sarlaben (February 2026, Gujarati, 18,600 villages, built on Plivo and Bhashini)	Open-source national stack with AI4Bharat models under MIT licence; GPU subsidised at ₹65 to ₹67 an hour under the ₹10,372 crore IndiaAI Mission. Jio said at its 2026 AGM it is building AI natively in Indian languages.
Consumer	Equal AI and Robin (call screening), Wispr Flow (dictation, betting on India), Reca (elder device)	Nearly empty. No consumer product with meaningful paid traction was found.

What the agents are used for

Sector	Use cases	Examples and claimed results (vendor-reported unless noted)
BFSI (the largest buyer)	EMI reminders and early-bucket collections, KYC verification, loan and card status, credit-card and loan sales, insurance renewals, fraud alerts, voice biometrics	A 25% to 35% lift in soft-bucket collections in Hindi and eight regional languages is a typical claim. RBI limits recovery calls to 8 am to 7 pm. Bolna gets 20% to 25% of its usage here; it serves 50+ BFSI clients including Bank of Baroda Cards, Aditya Birla Capital and Paytm.
E-commerce and D2C	Cash-on-delivery confirmation, cart abandonment, failed-delivery (NDR) rescheduling, order status, returns	COD confirmation is the single most common agent in India: return-to-origin rates reported falling from 28% to 30% down to 18% to 22%, at about ₹5 per AI contact against ₹20 for a human. 45% to 60% of customers who answer an NDR call confirm a new slot. Bolna gets about 40% of its usage from e-commerce.
Logistics and quick commerce	Rider hiring and onboarding, address verification, delivery rescheduling, rider coordination	Delhivery and Swiggy run rider hiring on SquadStack; Meesho's in-house bot runs 60,000 calls a day.
Recruitment and gig work	Candidate screening, interview scheduling, onboarding, merchant onboarding	Vahan.ai, Awign, Hyreo, Futwork (80% less human effort on merchant onboarding, per a Bolna case study).
Healthcare	Appointment booking and reminders, front desk, post-visit follow-up, pharmacy refills	Ringg books across 1,200 Practo clinics; Pype AI runs hospital front desks; Bharosa does phone-based medical assistance.
Real estate, auto, edtech	Lead qualification, site-visit and test-drive scheduling, admissions counselling	NoBroker (ConvoZen), Maruti, Spinny, Cars24; Edysor for colleges. Vendors claim qualification in under 90 seconds.

Sector	Use cases	Examples and claimed results (vendor-reported unless noted)
Government and agriculture	Farmer advisory, scheme information, utilities (FASTag, DigiYatra, power distributors)	MahaVISTAAR and Sarlaben deliver advisory by voice call; Sarlaben is expanding to 20 languages and 20,000 villages.
Consumer	Spam and scam call screening, dictation	Equal AI, Robin, Wispr Flow. Nobody sells a paid voice agent to a family yet.

Inbound (support, KYC, servicing, bookings, order status) is the smaller but higher-margin half; outbound (collections, reminders, lead qualification, cart recovery) is the volume half and the one regulators and buyers squeeze hardest.

Unit economics, and why the ceiling is a human

- A human telecaller costs ₹5 to ₹8 per connected minute, fully loaded ₹6 to ₹10 in tier-2 cities and ₹12 to ₹17 in metros. Every vendor prices against that.
- AI voice list prices run ₹2 to ₹12 a minute, most often ₹3 to ₹6; effective cost is two to four times the quote once platform fees, telephony and connect-rate losses are added. A cascaded stack at list prices is about ₹4.68 a minute, ₹6.13 with orchestration. In other words, an agent built on rented models matches a telecaller and does not undercut her.
- Outbound reality: connect rates of 46% to 48% and an average connected call of 1.6 minutes, so half the dials are paid for and wasted.
- Buyers therefore push outcome pricing: ₹8 to ₹25 per outcome, revenue-linked contracts, ₹85 to ₹165 per qualified lead. Model costs fell 60% to 80% from 2024 to 2026 (Sarvam streaming STT at ₹30 an hour), which is the only reason margins exist at all.
- The in-house threat is real: Meesho, Zomato, Bajaj Finserv and Swiggy build their own.

Regulation that shapes the market

- TCCCPR (TRAI's spam rules): the February 2025 amendment limited inferred consent to the life of the customer relationship and made explicit transactional consent valid for seven days; the 2026 Third Amendment makes robocall senders pre-declare their number series on the DLT ledger, obliges telcos to use AI to flag spam numbers, protects 140 and 160 series from spam labels, adds a ₹0.05 per minute A2P termination fee and a 15-day complaint appeal. Penalties run ₹2 to ₹10 lakh; 7.31 lakh notices went to unregistered telemarketers in 2025.

- Numbers: 140 series for promotional, 160 series for transactional, both needing DLT registration by a registered entity; CNAP caller-name display rolling out since March 2026.
- RBI's recovery-call window (8 am to 7 pm) and Fair Practices Code for collections; DPDP Rules (notified November 2025, phasing in to 2027) for recordings and consent.

What this means for the buildathon

- Outbound B2B sales and collections bots are the crowded, margin-less corner; the Bolna judges see dozens a week and have templates for them.
- The empty cells in the table above are consumer-paid voice, family-paid voice, and inbound services where the agent owns an outcome. Those buyers are not among the hundred enterprises, so no panel vendor competes for them and nobody prices them against a telecaller.
- Parent Line and Sugar Saathi sit in those empty cells with a dollar-paying buyer; Control Room sells to the panel vendors; Complaint Caller flips the direction of every call in the market.
- The sentence for Grey Baker: "India will be one of the largest voice markets in the world by minutes, and the margin goes to whoever owns the buyer. Families paying ₹999 a month are a buyer base none of the enterprise vendors can reach."

What actually wins

The winning shape is a consumer- or SMB-facing product, in an Indian language, over a plain phone call, aligned to a named YC request, with 20 to 50 real users and some rupees collected by Oct 31, and a stage demo that is a live call. Three different filters stack, and each rewards something different.

1. **Nov 3 shortlist** (Bolna team reading hundreds of forms). The 200-character line must be instantly legible: who, what, and why voice is essential rather than bolted on. The link must open to something that talks to the reader within 10 seconds (a web-call button or "get a call now"). The video must contain real call recordings with real users, not a slideshow.
2. **Nov 5 to 7 interview** (YC-style, probably 10 to 15 minutes). Expect: what did you build, who uses it, numbers, why you, why now, what is hard. Bolna's founders were rejected by YC until they had paying pilots, so expect "who pays?". Have ready: number of users, calls completed, answer rate, retention over the pilot days, rupees collected, two user quotes.
3. **Nov 20 stage** (crowd, Grey Baker, investors). A live phone call on stage in an Indian language that does something visibly useful in 60 seconds beats any slide. Have a recorded backup.

What YC is asking for right now. The Fall 2026 Requests for Startups name voice twice and agents often. Build inside one of these and your pitch to Grey Baker writes itself.

YC request (Fall 2026)	Author	Voice angle	Bolna example it matches
AI for the Aging Population	Max Kolysh	"Voice interfaces that can hold real conversations… Even Alexa and Google Home are frustrating for most seniors." Plus software for family caregivers.	None (open space)
Proving You're Human	Max Kolysh	Voice clones and deepfake calls drive fraud; wants a privacy-respecting trust layer "every bank, app, and video call checks."	None (open space)
AI-Powered Consumer Products for 1 Billion People	Raphael Schaad	Agents good enough to treat like people; per-user costs falling fast.	A voice layer on an existing app
The Primer	Andrew Miklas	Adaptive AI tutor teaching young kids reading, writing, arithmetic.	A voice tutor for kids
New Operating Systems for the Physical World	Charlie Warren	Route and track work across agents, robots and humans in field ops.	A hands-free tool for drivers or field workers
Multiplayer AI; A Cloud for Small Software	Aaron Epstein; Pete Koomen	Agent-adjacent, hard to make voice-native in 16 days.	None

What Bolna wants to showcase. Indian languages, real telephony, and a use case outside its 15 agent templates. Collections, lead qualification, cart abandonment, COD confirmation, recruitment screening and clinic front desks are already templates, and YC's Spring and Summer 2025 batches already funded Novoflow (clinic receptionist), Veritus, Qualify.bot and others. Avoid them.

What Grey Baker's history rewards. An MVP shipped in two weeks, users recruited by hand, early revenue however small, a crisp one-sentence pitch, knowing your numbers, and an honest "I don't know" when you don't.

New lead: weekly check-in calls for nutritionists, piloted with Diet Mojo

This is now the strongest idea in the doc, because it removes the biggest risk in every other one: finding real users who will take the call within 16 days. Diet Mojo, the Bengaluru nutrition practice where your mom works, already has paying clients who expect a weekly check-in call on WhatsApp. Build the agent that makes that call, and hand her a one-page summary per client so she only calls back the people who need her.

200-character line (192): "An AI that calls every diet client weekly in their language, logs weight, meals, water, sleep and cravings, and hands the nutritionist a one-page summary so she can coach twice as many people."

Why it beats Parent Line for this buildathon

Question	Parent Line	Nutritionist check-ins
Who is user number one	Your own parent, then cold outreach to NRI families	Diet Mojo's existing clients, from day one
Who pays	Adult children; unproven	Clients already pay ₹1,400 to ₹3,750 per program; the nutritionist pays for hours saved
Will the person pick up and stay on	The parent never asked for the call	The client signed up for weekly check-ins and expects them
Retention	The weakest point in the critique	Tied to a paid program with a goal and an end date
Expert feedback while you build	None	A nutritionist who knows what a good check-in sounds like, every evening
Outcome you can show by Oct 31	Answer rate, mood	Weights logged, adherence, nutritionist minutes saved, clients per nutritionist
Medical-advice risk	Moderate	Lower: the agent collects, the nutritionist decides

Question	Parent Line	Nutritionist check-ins
Bolna showcase	High	High: multilingual, dynamic variables, extractions, workflows, WhatsApp

Parent Line stays the expansion story: the same engine, a different caller list.

What Diet Mojo is today (site): weight, diabetes and cholesterol management plus physiotherapy, in JP Nagar, Bengaluru. Fixed-price programs from ₹1,400 (Korean Glossy Skin) to ₹3,750 (Pre-Diabetic Plan), including a 21-Day Gut Healing Plan at ₹3,500 and a 21 Days Weight Loss Challenge at ₹2,400. Prices are also shown in USD, so some clients are likely abroad. Free consultation by form, WhatsApp, phone or email. 60 Google reviews rated Excellent; reviewers mention daily coach check-ins.

How the product works

1. The nutritionist adds a client: name, language, goal, program, current plan, preferred call time. A Google Sheet is enough for v1; Bolna has a Google Sheets outbound tutorial.
2. The day before, a WhatsApp message: "Diet Mojo's assistant will call you tomorrow at 7 pm for your weekly check-in." This sets expectations and lifts the answer rate.
3. The Bolna agent calls at the chosen time for 5 to 7 minutes, in English, Kannada, Hindi or Tamil, and asks what she asks today: this week's weight, each meal against the plan, water, sleep, steps or exercise, cravings and eating out, digestion and bloating, energy and mood, and any questions for her. Dynamic variables carry the client's plan, goal and last week's numbers ("Last week you were at 72.4 kg").
4. Post-call extractions produce structured fields: weight, adherence per meal, water, sleep hours, red flags (dizziness, fainting, very low intake, high sugar reading, pregnancy, medicine change) and open questions.
5. A webhook writes them to a dashboard and sends her one WhatsApp summary, red flags first.
6. She reviews, adjusts the plan and replies. The agent never changes a plan or gives advice; it answers only from a knowledge base of her approved swaps and recipes, and says "I'll pass that to ma'am" for everything else.

WhatsApp calls versus a phone call. Her clients are used to WhatsApp calls. Meta's WhatsApp Business Calling API allows business-initiated calls in India (only the US, Canada, Egypt, Vietnam and Nigeria are excluded), but only after the client grants call permission; permission requests are capped at one a day and two a week, and four unanswered calls revoke it. It supports SIP, and Bolna supports bring-your-own SIP trunks, so a WhatsApp-to-Bolna bridge is plausible, but neither side documents it. For the

buildathon, use a normal call from Bolna's shared +91 number plus the WhatsApp reminder, and ask in the Bolna Slack whether WhatsApp calling works. If it does, "the agent calls you on WhatsApp" is a standout demo.

Unit economics

- A 6-minute weekly call is about 26 minutes a month: roughly ₹200 per client at Bolna's standard ₹7.8 a minute, about ₹120 with bring-your-own keys.
- That is 5% to 15% of what the client pays. Third-party coaching tiers with weekly check-ins sit at ₹2,999 a month; HealthifyMe's cheapest human-coach tier offers about two calls a month. The agent makes weekly contact affordable at any price point.
- Price to the nutritionist: ₹299 to ₹499 per active client a month, or ₹2,999 a month for up to 25 clients.
- Time saved, to be measured with your mom: if a human check-in takes about 15 minutes, 40 clients is 10 hours a week. With the agent she reads a summary in about 3 minutes and calls back only flagged clients, roughly 4 hours in total. That frees about 6 hours a week, or room for twice the clients.

Evidence that weekly contact matters. In a small study of 48 women, weekly sessions produced 4.76 kg average loss against 3.66 kg fortnightly and 1.82 kg monthly. A 2024 review of accountability in weight-loss programs found that professional follow-up beyond self-motivation increased adherence. Both are small or observational, but they support the core claim: more frequent check-ins help, and cost is what stops them.

Market

Segment	Size	Source
Independent nutritionists and dietitians in India	About 12,800 listed businesses (Dec 2024); an undercount, since many practices run on Instagram and WhatsApp	Rentech directory
Coach-led health platforms	HealthifyMe claims 2,000 coaches; Sugar.fit, Fitterfly and BeatO run counsellor calls; HealthifyMe's employee costs were about ₹85 crore in FY24	Entrackr, Value for Startups
India personalized nutrition	$213M in 2025 to $289M by 2030	MarketsandMarkets
Adjacent check-in professions	Physiotherapists (Diet Mojo offers physio), fitness trainers, diabetes educators, yoga teachers	Same weekly pattern

Segment	Size	Source
US comparable	Fay raised a $50M Series B at a $500M valuation (Feb 2025) for a network of 2,300+ insurance-covered dietitians	MedCity News

Bottom-up for Indian solo practitioners: 10,000 practitioners × 30 clients × ₹300 a month is about ₹90 crore ($10M) a year. That alone is small. The venture case is the wedge: self-serve to solo nutritionists (Grey Baker's Dependabot playbook), then coach platforms that already pay for counsellor calls, then other check-in professions, then US dietitians on networks like Fay.

Risks and how to handle them

- Clients may feel downgraded from a human call. Frame it as a pre-check-in, keep a short voice note or reply from her after every summary, and let any client opt back to a human call. Measure satisfaction weekly.
- One design partner is one nutritionist's style. Onboard two or three more nutritionists from her network in week two; going from one to five practitioners is the traction slide.
- Self-reported weight is noisy. Ask for a photo of the scale on WhatsApp after the call.
- Health data under the DPDP Act: get explicit consent from each client, disclose that it is an AI at the start of every call, and store transcripts rather than audio.
- Red flags: hard escalation rules for dizziness, fainting, very low intake, pregnancy, medicine changes and high sugar readings, sent to her within a minute.
- "Isn't this a Bolna template?" The difference is client memory across weeks, plan-aware questions, and the practitioner dashboard and billing that turn it into SaaS.

Revised 16 days

1. **Oct 17 to 18:** sit with her for an hour, note how three real check-ins go (with client consent), write her question list, and pick five to ten clients who agree to try it.
2. **Oct 19 to 21:** agent v0 on Bolna; test on her and on you; first five client calls.
3. **Oct 22 to 25:** summary dashboard and WhatsApp summary; every willing client; she edits the prompt every evening. Track answer rate, completed check-ins and her minutes per client.
4. **Oct 26 to 28:** onboard two or three more nutritionists; charge for a month.
5. **Oct 29 to 30:** video with a real consented client call, her reaction, and the numbers.
6. **Oct 31:** submit.

Questions to ask your mom

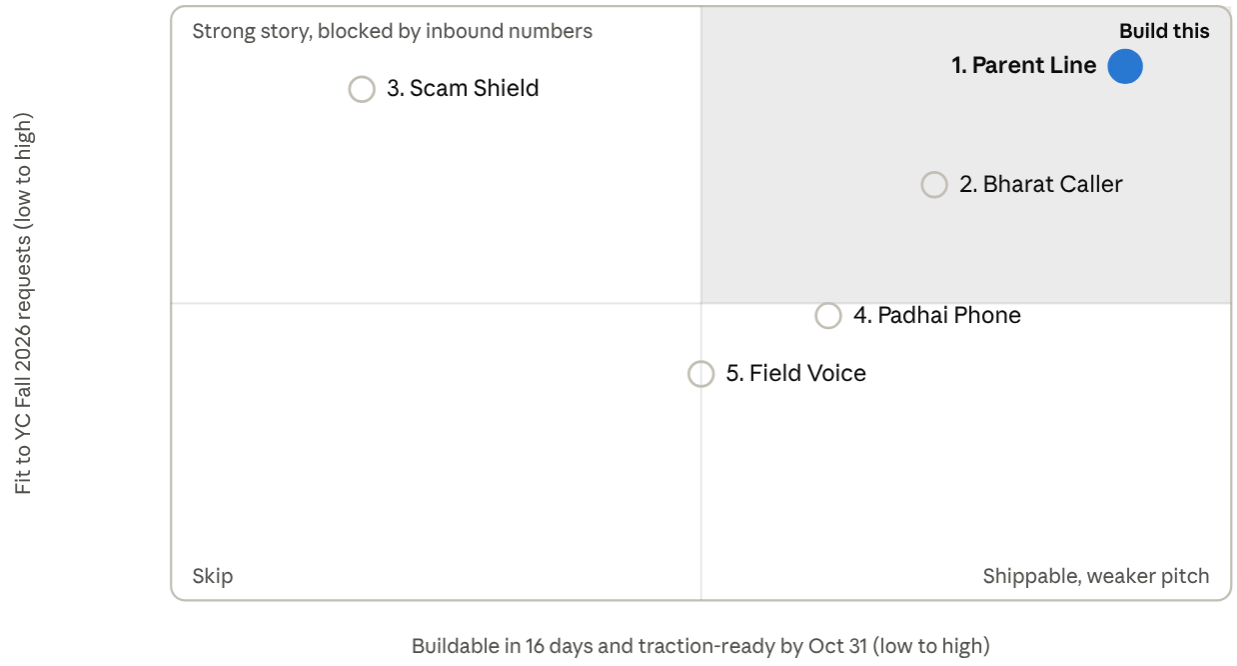
- [ ] How many active clients does she have, and how long does a weekly check-in take?

- [ ] What does she ask, in what order, and which answers make her change the plan?
- [ ] Which languages do her clients use on calls?
- [ ] Would five to ten clients try an AI check-in next week, and which ones?
- [ ] What would she pay per client per month to get those hours back?
- [ ] Does she know three other nutritionists who would try it?

Idea shortlist, ranked

Recommendation: build Parent Line (daily check-in calls for ageing parents) with scam-flagging as its headline feature. It hits the strongest voice request in YC's current list, needs only Bolna features that work on day one, and is the easiest idea to put real paying users behind in 16 days.

Only Parent Line is both shippable in 16 days and squarely in a YC request



five ideas on YC fit versus buildability · 2x2

Positions are my judgement from the scores below. Scam Shield has the best story but cannot receive calls without a registered company; it belongs inside Parent Line as a feature.

Idea	Novelty	Stage wow	YC fit	Bolna showcase	Buildable in 16 days	Traction by Oct 31
1. Parent Line	3	5	5	5	5	5
2. Bharat Caller	4	5	4	5	4	3

Idea	Novelty	Stage wow	YC fit	Bolna showcase	Buildable in 16 days	Traction by Oct 31
3. Scam Shield	4	5	5	4	2	2
4. Padhai Phone	3	3	4	4	4	3
5. Field Voice	3	3	4	4	4	2

Scores are 1 to 5, my judgement from the research above.

1. Parent Line: daily check-in calls for ageing parents, for children who live away

200-character line: "Parent Line calls your ageing parents every day in their language, chats about meds, meals and mood, and WhatsApps you a summary. It flags scams, falls or confusion instantly."

- **Who pays:** adult children in metros or abroad (NRIs), ₹499 to ₹999 per parent per month. Reachable within days through r/nri, NRI WhatsApp and Facebook groups, LinkedIn, alumni groups, your own family.
- **Why a phone call:** the parent installs nothing. A ringing phone that speaks Tamil, Kannada or Hindi is the only interface that works at 75.
- **Why now:** YC's aging-population request names this almost verbatim. Fewer than 1% of Indian elderly have organised care (Samarth). Digital-arrest scams took ₹4,057 crore from 2022 to May 2026 and target exactly this group (Wikipedia).
- **Build on Bolna:** outbound via shared +91 numbers; one multilingual prompt with Sarvam saaras:v4 STT and Bulbul v4 Flash code-mixed TTS; dynamic variables for name, meds, children's names and yesterday's summary so the call has continuity; extractions for mood (1 to 5), meds taken, meals, pain or fall, scam signal (police, CBI, KYC, OTP, parcel, arrest, blocked bank), loneliness, wants a callback; a workflow that sends the WhatsApp summary (AiSensy, with Twilio WhatsApp sandbox, SMS or email as the v1 fallback); batches with calling-hour guardrails for the daily schedule; the web search tool for weather and cricket small talk; a custom function "book a call with my son" that triggers a call to the child.
- **Family side:** a Next.js app on Vercel with onboarding (parent profile, language, schedule, meds), a dashboard of daily summaries and a mood trend, a "Call now" button, and a Razorpay or Stripe payment link.
- **Stage demo:** a live call to a real grandparent in Kannada; the audience hears the conversation; the WhatsApp summary appears on screen seconds after hangup.
- **Competition:** US: intouch.family, JoyCalls, Hello Gloria, ElliQ. India: Silver Saathi (app), ELRO (device), Reca (voice-first for Indian elders; verify at heyreca.com), Khyaal (no AI calls), Samarth (human-run). Differentiate on phone-call-first, vernacular and code-mixed speech, scam safety, the WhatsApp family loop, and day-to-day continuity.

- **Risks:** investor scepticism of "companion apps" (answer with answer rate, days-in-a-row retention and paying families); health claims (position as check-in and family alerting, not medical); vulnerable users (disclose it is an AI, keep a human escalation path).

2. Bharat Caller: an agent that phones local businesses for you, in their language

Line: "Tell Bharat Caller what you need, 'plumber in Indiranagar today under ₹600', and it calls 5 shops in Kannada or Hindi at once, negotiates, and returns quotes in 3 minutes."

- Fits YC's consumer-for-1-billion request. India's services economy is phone-first and unorganised, so the phone is the API. Nothing like it exists in India; in the US there are Simple AI (YC S24), Callio and Leximo.
- Bolna: parallel outbound (paid tier for 10 concurrent), multilingual, extractions for price, availability and address, aggregated into one answer.
- Highest stage wow: five live calls in parallel with results filling a table.
- Risks: businesses hang up on bots and disclosure ethics; monetisation is lead-gen later; judges may call it "Duplex redux". Users are easy to get, revenue is not.

3. Scam Shield: an AI that answers your parents' unknown calls and defuses digital-arrest scams

Line: "Scam Shield answers unknown calls for seniors in their language, questions the caller, blocks digital-arrest, KYC and courier scams, and WhatsApps the family, with a voice safe-word against clones."

- Fits two YC requests (proving you're human, aging population). Truecaller for Business is a Diamond sponsor. The Supreme Court has pushed for AI use against digital arrest. The strongest "why now" of the five.
- Blocker: it needs an inbound Indian number, so a compliance application with CIN and GST. Only viable if you have a registered company. Otherwise the demo runs on web call or a US Twilio number, which weakens the story. The parent also has to set conditional call forwarding, a real setup hurdle.
- Best used as the headline feature inside Parent Line (scam-pattern detection during check-ins plus a "verify this caller" callback), not as a standalone v1.

4. Padhai Phone: a daily 10-minute reading and arithmetic tutor over a phone call, for kids without smartphones

- Fits YC's Primer request and Bolna's first example. Phone-first is distinct from Rocket Learning's Appu (WhatsApp), YoLearn (device) and ZigZu (English app).

- Needs a school, NGO or low-fee-school partner for traction; kids on a live stage are unpredictable; YC's appetite for India edtech is cautious.

5. Field Voice: hands-free job logging and dispatch for field technicians and riders, in their language

- Fits YC's physical-world request and Bolna's fourth example. B2B; needs one design-partner company (an AC-repair chain, a logistics fleet) by week one to be real.

Avoid

Collections, lead qualification, cart abandonment, recruitment screening, clinic front desk (Bolna templates; YC S25 has Novoflow, Veritus and others). Agri advisory (AMUL Sarlaben, Farm Vaidya, the government's VoicERA). Blue-collar hiring (Vahan AI's CEO is a speaker). Any generic "voice assistant for X".

Five more ideas, researched

None of these beats Parent Line on buildability plus traction inside 16 days, but two are credible alternates: OPD Intake Line if you have a doctor as a design partner, and Control Room if you want a developer-tool story for Grey Baker. Sugar Saathi is the natural vertical wedge if a general check-in call proves too thin.

Idea	Novelty	Stage wow	YC fit	Bolna showcase	Buildable in 16 days	Traction by Oct 31
6. OPD Intake Line	4	3	4	5	4	3
7. Maa Line	4	4	3	5	3	2
8. Complaint Caller	4	5	4	2	2	3
9. Control Room	4	3	4	4	3	2
10. Sugar Saathi	3	3	4	5	4	3

6. OPD Intake Line: pre-visit history taking and post-visit follow-up calls, for clinics and hospitals

Line: "OPD Intake Line calls each patient the evening before their appointment, takes their history in Kannada or Hindi, hands the doctor a one-page note, and calls after the visit to check they started the medicines."

- **Why now:** Indian primary-care consultations averaged about two minutes in the BMJ Open review (2015 data, 67 countries). A 2024 Kolkata study found a 98.6-minute wait for a 6.5-minute consult. A CAG audit in Jammu and Kashmir found 58% of patients examined for under five minutes. Doctors have no time to take a history; a phone call the night before does it for them.
- **Who exists:** EkaScribe and Augnito transcribe during the consult, not before. Pype AI ($1.2M pre-seed, Kalaari) does voice front-desk for hospitals. Co Doctor (brizAI) does WhatsApp pre-consultation. In the US, Hippocratic AI runs intake, pre-op and post-discharge calls at a $3.5B valuation and claims 8 to 10 million patient calls a month, which validates the category. Nobody found does vernacular phone intake in India.
- **Bolna build:** outbound via shared +91 numbers; knowledge base holding the clinic's intake template; extractions producing the structured note; webhook to a doctor dashboard; multilingual prompt.
- **Traction path:** one doctor you know, 20 patients a day, a ₹2,000 to ₹5,000 monthly fee per doctor. Measure consult minutes saved and no-shows avoided.
- **Risks:** health data is sensitive under the DPDP Act (explicit consent, no reuse); the agent must never advise; doctors change habits slowly; you need the doctor partner by week one.

7. Maa Line: two-way check-in calls for new mothers, sold to maternity hospitals and NGOs

Line: "Maa Line calls new mothers twice a week in their language, asks about feeding, bleeding, fever and the baby's weight, answers their questions, and escalates danger signs to the hospital's nurse."

- **Why now:** the channel is proven at national scale but only one-way. ARMMAN's Kilkari and mMitra report 75 to 78 million women and children reached with pre-recorded voice calls; two-way support exists only as chatbots and WhatsApp pilots in four states. Noora Health runs its remote engagement service on WhatsApp and IVR with a 20-person medical team triaging about 10,000 messages a day in eight languages; that triage labour is what an AI call absorbs. Noora's Care Companion Program reports 18% lower newborn mortality (self-reported).
- **Buyers:** private maternity hospitals as a package add-on, NGOs such as ARMMAN and Noora, state health departments later.
- **Bolna build:** outbound batches on a schedule, multilingual prompt, extractions that flag danger signs, call transfer to a nurse, WhatsApp follow-up.
- **Risks:** clinical triage must be conservative and reviewed by a clinician; consent and DPDP; hospital and NGO sales cycles are months, so real users inside 16 days are unlikely without an existing relationship. YC may read it as NGO-shaped.

8. Complaint Caller: an agent that calls Indian customer-care lines for you, holds, navigates the IVR and logs the ticket

Line: "Tell Complaint Caller 'my Airtel bill is wrong' and it calls, waits on hold, presses the right keys, argues in Hindi, and WhatsApps you the ticket number."

- **Why now:** ServiceNow's India customer-experience study found Indians spent 30.7 hours each on hold in 2023, about 15 billion hours and $55 billion of lost output, and its 2025 edition found 90% of Indians have spent over four hours resolving an issue in telecom, retail or finance. No consumer product does this in India. Google's Hold for Me (2020) only waits; Simple AI (YC S24) makes calls on your behalf in the US.
- **YC fit:** consumer product for a billion people, viral by nature, and the "agents talking to agents" story. Expect Grey Baker to ask how it makes money (per call, subscription, or the company side) and whether companies will block AI callers.
- **Bolna blocker:** Bolna's docs cover DTMF input from callers and real-time event injection for graph agents, but nothing on sending key presses during an outbound call. Without outbound DTMF the agent cannot get past "press 1 for Hindi". Confirm in Slack; the fallback is driving the IVR leg through Plivo directly, which weakens the "built on Bolna" story. Long holds also burn minutes: a 25-minute hold costs about ₹150 at ₹6 a minute.

9. Control Room: a multiplayer supervisor console for voice agents, built on Bolna

Line: "Control Room lets a team watch 50 live AI calls, whisper a correction into one, take over when it goes wrong, hand it back, and turn every intervention into a prompt fix."

- **Why now:** YC's Multiplayer AI request asks for shared live agent sessions where teammates can watch, redirect and hand off agent work. Voice is the highest-stakes agent surface and most platforms lack this: Vapi exposes listen and control URLs, Synthflow added silent monitoring only in July 2026, Regal and Famulor sell takeover. Bolna has call transfer and event injection but no supervisor UI. Agnost AI (YC S26, a Symphony sponsor) does post-hoc analytics, not live control.
- **Buyers:** BPOs and enterprises running Bolna agents for collections and support that need a human in the loop for compliance; Bolna itself as partner or acquirer.
- **Grey Baker fit:** a developer tool with a Dependabot-style wedge. The Bolna judges will either love it or feel it belongs to them.
- **Bolna feasibility:** event injection gives whisper-like redirects and call transfer gives takeover, but live audio listening is not exposed by the hosted API as far as the docs show. A realistic 16-day scope is a live transcript wall from webhooks, inject, and transfer.
- **Risks:** users are Bolna customers, so paying traction in 16 days is unlikely; the demo is a screen, not a phone call on stage.

10. Sugar Saathi: two-minute daily check-in calls for people with diabetes or hypertension, sold through doctors and patient-support programs

Line: "Sugar Saathi calls your father every morning in Tamil, asks his sugar reading and whether he took metformin, nudges him on food, and alerts you and his doctor if readings drift."

- **Why now:** ICMR-INDIAB (Lancet, 2023) puts diabetes at 11.4% and hypertension at 35.5% of adults, about 315 million people, plus 136 million with prediabetes. A vendor estimate says nearly half of chronic-therapy patients stop within a year. The incumbents are human call centres: the HCAH and QMS merger (September 2026) combines 160+ pharma patient-support programs, 1.2 million patients and 2,000+ staff. Apps such as BeatO and Fitterfly ($15M raised) need smartphones and literacy; a phone call reaches the 60+ cohort.
- **Buyers:** pharma patient-support programs (per patient per month), diabetologists, insurers; children of patients as the consumer channel, which is Parent Line's buyer.
- **Bolna build:** the Parent Line stack plus a function call to log readings and keyword biasing so numbers transcribe correctly.
- **Risks:** the medical-advice boundary; readings dictated over the phone are error-prone; a clinician must be in the loop; pharma sales cycles are long, so the consumer channel is the 16-day route.

Parent Line: critique

The three weakest points are cost per call against a ₹499 price, the fact that the parent rather than the buyer decides retention, and a moat that is distribution and data rather than technology. None is fatal, but each needs a numeric answer before the Nov 5 interview.

1. **Cost per minute can exceed the price.** Bolna's standard rate is 6¢ a minute for STT, LLM and TTS, plus a 2¢ platform fee, plus Plivo telephony at ₹0.40 to ₹0.60, about ₹7.8 a minute all-in. A four-minute daily call costs ₹936 a month against a ₹499 price. The table below shows what closes the gap: two-minute calls, the Pilot plan, bring-your-own-keys, and a ₹999 tier for daily calls.
2. **The parent decides retention, the child only decides purchase.** Children buy out of guilt; parents may refuse "a computer calling me", find it patronising, or tire of it after two weeks. inTouch and JoyCalls publish testimonials, not retention curves. Give the parent control (time, voice, topics, "stop" ends it), make the call useful to the parent (weather, cricket, temple timings, a "call my son" button, reminders they asked for) and position it as the parent's assistant that keeps the family informed, not surveillance. Measure answer rate and days-in-a-row from day one.

3. **Investors are wary of "AI companion" products.** Expect Grey Baker to ask whether this is a feature of Emoha (₹1,999 to ₹10,999 a month with human care managers), Samarth (₹10,999 to ₹16,999 per family) or Khyaal (claims over 1 million users, no AI calls). The answer: they are channels as much as competitors. You are the ₹500 daily layer underneath their ₹10,000 monthly human visits, and software-only against Reca's Wi-Fi device plus ₹200 a month membership.
4. **The moat is not the tech.** Anyone can build this on Bolna in a week, and Bolna could ship it as a template. The defensible assets are distribution into NRI and alumni communities, a longitudinal baseline per parent that turns daily answers into anomaly detection, trust and brand with families, and integrations (ambulance, pharmacy, hospital, operator partners). Lead the pitch with retention data, not features.
5. **Speech recognition on elderly, dialectal speech is weak.** Shared-task systems for elderly Tamil speech report word error rates of 29% to 40%, roughly a third of words wrong, before hearing loss and code-mixing. Design for it: short closed questions, read-back confirmations, keyword biasing for medicine names, Sarvam saaras v4, and a keypad fallback ("press 1 if you took your medicines"). Test with five real elders before promising anything to a buyer.
6. **Safety and liability.** A phone call cannot detect a fall, and the agent must never give medical advice. A missed red flag and a false alarm both destroy trust. Scope it as check-in plus family alerting, disclose that it is an AI at the start of every call, write hard escalation rules (any mention of chest pain, a fall, police, or money goes to the family within a minute), and keep a human path through an operator partner.
7. **Consent and data law.** Daily outbound calls need the parent's own consent, not the child's, recorded verbally on the first call, with "stop" honoured instantly. Bolna's shared +91 numbers may be tagged as spam by Truecaller, which lowers answer rates; ask the family to save the number. The DPDP Rules were notified on 14 November 2025 with most obligations phasing in by about May 2027: standalone consent notices, purpose limitation, and no reuse of recordings for model training. Health mentions in recordings make this stricter, so store transcripts, not audio, by default.
8. **The ARPU is small for a venture outcome.** ₹499 to ₹999 a month is $6 to $12. $100M of revenue needs about a million paying families, which only happens through channels: insurers' senior plans, hospital discharge programs, elder-care operators, and pharma patient-support programs. The market-size section below puts numbers on each.
9. **What Grey Baker will push on.** Why you, and why now rather than two years ago (answer: Indic STT and TTS crossed usable quality in 2025 to 2026 and Bolna made a four-minute vernacular call cost under ₹30). What did a user do that surprised you. The retention curve. Who pays, how much, and how you got them. Why Khyaal or Emoha

will not copy you. What the wedge becomes: Scam Shield as a trust layer, Sugar Saathi as chronic care, or the operating system for care operators. Prepare one-line answers with numbers.

10. **Stage risk.** A live call to a real elder can fail: no answer, noise, a confused pause. Prime the parent, keep a second volunteer on standby, and have the recording ready.

Kill criteria. If by Oct 22 fewer than 60% of scheduled calls are answered, or two of five parents ask to stop, switch to Sugar Saathi (prescribed by a doctor, so the parent expects the call) or OPD Intake Line.

Cost per family per month (₹91 per dollar; telephony ₹0.50 a minute; platform fee 2¢ a minute applies on every plan)

Stack	₹ per minute	2 min a day	4 min a day	4 min, weekdays only
Bolna standard (6¢ bundled models)	7.8	468	936	686
Bolna Pilot plan (4.2¢ bundled)	6.2	372	744	546
Bring your own keys (Sarvam STT and TTS, gpt-5-mini)	4.5	270	540	396
Self-hosted open-source Bolna, later	2.7	162	324	238

At ₹499 only two-minute calls are profitable on any plan you can use during the buildathon; a four-minute daily call needs the ₹999 tier or a weekday schedule. Bring-your-own-keys figures are estimates from Sarvam's published rates (₹30 an hour STT, ₹30 per 10,000 characters TTS) and typical gpt-5-mini token use.

Parent Line: market size

The honest number is about 7 million Indian households that can pay today, worth roughly ₹4,200 to ₹8,400 crore a year ($460M to $920M) at ₹499 to ₹999 a month, with the NRI slice paying in dollars for a service delivered in rupees. A venture-scale outcome needs the B2B channels on top: insurers, hospitals, elder-care operators and pharma programs, which add another ₹500 to ₹600 crore of near-term addressable spend and, more importantly, distribution.

The population, from the primary sources

Indicator	Value	Source
People aged 60+ in India, 2022	149 million (10.5% of population)	UNFPA India Ageing Report 2023
Projected 60+ in 2036 and 2050	227 million (15%) and 347 million (20.8%)	UNFPA, same report
Elderly living alone	5.7%	LASI Wave 1 fact sheet, 2017-18, n = 31,902
Elderly living with spouse or others, no children in the house	20.3%	LASI
Elderly who are literate	39.6% (24.2% of women)	LASI
Any limitation in instrumental daily activities (includes making phone calls, taking medicines)	48.0%	LASI
Had a fall in the past two years	22.9%	LASI
Hearing problems; using a hearing aid	9.6%; 0.7%	LASI
Diagnosed diabetes; measured hypertension	14.2%; 36.2%	LASI
Took medicine without consulting a provider in past year	43.4%	LASI
Hospitalised in past 12 months; of which private	7.9%; 59.1%	LASI
Health insurance coverage	18.2%	LASI
Mean monthly income of an elderly person	₹5,803	LASI
Overseas Indians, January 2026	37.3 million (17.8M NRIs, 19.5M PIOs)	MEA

Three things in that table shape the product. Only 40% of elders can read, so WhatsApp and apps fail where a phone call works. Half have trouble with tasks like making calls or taking medicines, so the call must come to them and the agent must do the dialling. And 26% live with no child in the house, which is the daily-check-in population: about 39 million people, or roughly 23 million households once couples are counted once.

Who can pay, bottom-up

Segment	Households (estimate)	Price a month	Revenue a year	Basis
NRI children with a parent 60+ in India	3 to 4 million	₹999 ($12)	₹3,600 to ₹4,800 crore	17.8M NRIs, roughly 60% working-age, about half with a living parent 60+, siblings share a parent; my estimate
Metro professionals with parents in another city	3 to 4 million	₹499	₹1,800 to ₹2,400 crore	23M child-free elderly households, top 15% by income; my estimate
Elder-care operators, white-label daily layer	0.3 to 0.5 million seniors	₹100 to ₹200 per seat	₹36 to ₹120 crore	Emoha claims 60,000 to 100,000 seniors, Samarth 40,000, Khyaal 1 million app users, plus Anvayaa and Portea
Health insurers, senior wellness and adherence programs	2.7 million insured elders (10% of the 18.2% covered)	₹50 to ₹100 per member	₹160 to ₹320 crore	LASI coverage rate; insurers fund programs that cut claims
Hospitals, 30-day post-discharge follow-up	7 million private admissions a year	₹300 per episode	₹210 crore	7.9% of 149M hospitalised, 59% private
Pharma patient-support programs, chronic 60+	1.2 million patients in one merged platform alone	₹100 to ₹200 per patient	₹140 to ₹290 crore	HCAH and QMS merger, 160+ programs

TAM for the consumer product is the 23 million child-free elderly households; SAM is the 7 million whose children can pay ₹500 to ₹1,000 a month, worth ₹4,200 to ₹8,400 crore a year; a realistic SOM for a three-year plan is 1% of SAM, about 70,000 families and ₹84 crore ($9M) of annual revenue at ₹999. That is a good company, not a YC fund-returner, which is why the B2B rows matter: they are both revenue and the cheapest way to reach a million families.

Pricing anchors and comparables

Comparable	What it is	Price or capital	Source
Samarth (India)	Human care managers, per family	₹10,999 to ₹16,999 a month	plans
Emoha (India)	Human care plans	₹1,999 to ₹10,999 a month; $17.9M raised	plans
Reca (India)	Wi-Fi voice companion device for Indian elders	device plus ₹200 a month	heyreca.com
inTouch (EU)	Daily AI phone calls, mood tracking	€29.90 a month	intouch.family
JoyCalls (US)	Daily AI phone companion, family report	$19 to $30 a month (competitor-reported)	HomeCare
ElliQ, Intuition Robotics (US)	Companion robot	$83M raised; a 2026 Medicaid reimbursement in Washington reported, unverified	TechCrunch
Papa (US)	Human companions for seniors	$240M raised, $1.4B valuation (2021)	Fierce Healthcare
India senior-care market reports	Senior living and geriatric care	$4.5B (2026, Mordor, senior living) to $50B (2026, Coherent, geriatric services); definitions vary tenfold	Mordor, Coherent

The pricing arbitrage is the pitch: an NRI child pays what inTouch charges in Europe, ₹2,700 a month, and the call is delivered for under ₹300. Start at ₹999 for the NRI segment and let the domestic ₹499 tier follow once calls are two minutes.

How to say it to Grey Baker in two sentences. "149 million Indians are over 60 and a quarter of them live without a child in the house; their children, 18 million of them abroad, already pay ₹2,000 to ₹17,000 a month to human care companies for a weekly visit. We are the ₹999 daily layer underneath that, and the same call sells to insurers, hospitals and pharma programs that already pay call centres to do it badly."

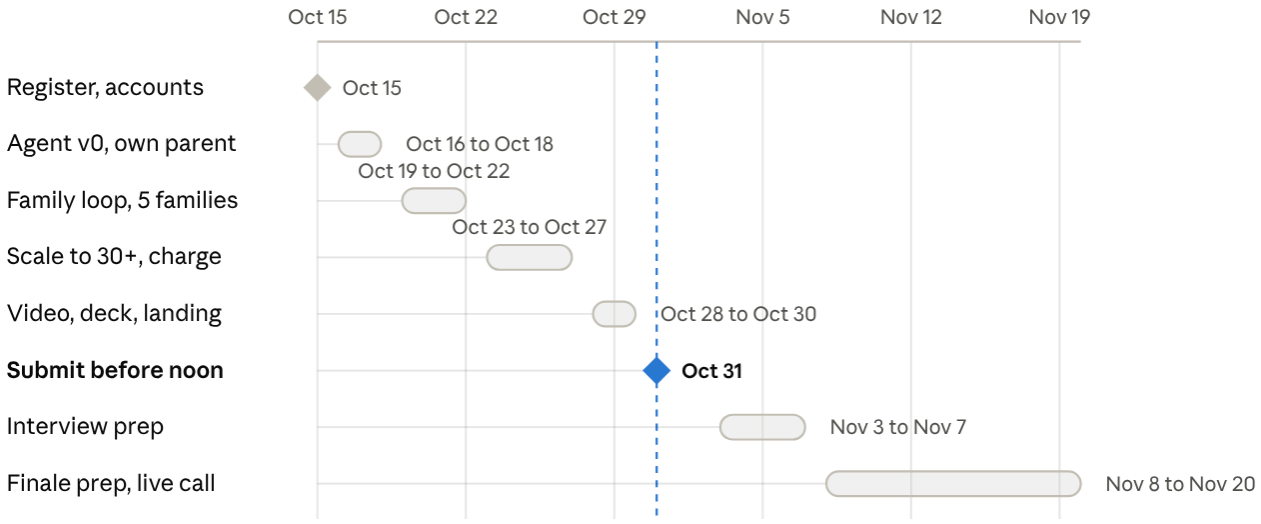
Estimates marked "my estimate" are derived from the cited population figures; no survey of Indian willingness to pay for AI check-in calls exists, which is exactly what your 16-day pilot produces.

Execution plan: 16 days to submission, then two gates

Ship a calling agent to your own parent by day 3, have five families on daily calls by day 7, charge money by day 12, and spend the last three days only on the submission assets. The pilot keeps running after Oct 31 so your numbers are bigger at the interview than on the form.

Users by day 7, money by day 12, assets only in the last three days

Parent Line build plan by week, 2026



build plan timeline · Oct 15 to Nov 20, 2026

The pilot keeps running through the submission line, so the interview numbers beat the form numbers.

1. **Day 0, Oct 15: register and unblock.** Apply on the buildathon page (idea: yes; be honest about "since when"). Join the Bolna Builders Slack, introduce the project, request Web Call SDK access, ask how sponsor credits are distributed. Create accounts on Bolna (top up $10 so you can call unverified numbers), Sarvam, Deepgram ($200), Cartesia, OpenAI, Vercel. Register interest for Symphony. Start a build-in-public thread on X or LinkedIn tagging @bolna_dev; organisers notice.
2. **Days 1 to 3, Oct 16 to 18: an agent that calls your own parent.** One multilingual Bolna agent: Sarvam saaras:v4 STT, gpt-5-mini, Bulbul v4 Flash code-mixed voice. Prompt: warm, 4 to 6 minutes, asks about meds, meals, sleep, mood and anything worrying, never gives medical advice, ends with "I'll call tomorrow". Dynamic variables: parent name, language, children's names, meds list, yesterday's summary. Extractions: mood,

meds_taken, ate_meals, pain_or_fall, scam_signal, wants_family_call, free-text summary. Run Bolna's awkward-case script (interruptions, silence, language switch, "stop").

3. **Days 4 to 7, Oct 19 to 22: the family loop and five pilot families.** Next.js on Vercel: onboarding (parent profile, schedule, language), a webhook receiver storing executions, a dashboard of daily cards and a mood trend, a "Call now" button. Daily scheduling via Bolna batches with calling-hour guardrails and auto-retry. WhatsApp summary via the AiSensy node if template approval is quick; otherwise Twilio WhatsApp sandbox, SMS or email for v1. Recruit five families from your network, start daily calls, collect feedback every evening.
4. **Days 8 to 12, Oct 23 to 27: 20 to 50 families, and money.** Post in NRI subreddits and groups, LinkedIn, alumni groups. Target 30+ parents on daily calls. Add a Razorpay or Stripe link at ₹499/month and get at least three to five paying. Ship the scam flag: on scam_signal, WhatsApp the family immediately and have the agent gently coach the parent ("police never arrest over the phone"). Instrument answer rate, average call length, days-in-a-row, flags raised, and an NPS question to the children.
5. **Days 13 to 15, Oct 28 to 30: submission assets.** Landing page with a web-call "Talk to Parent Line" button and "Get a demo call on your phone". A 2 to 3 minute video: 20s problem (your own parent's story), 60s real subtitled call recording, 30s WhatsApp summary and dashboard, 30s traction numbers and user quotes, 10s ask. An 8 to 10 slide YC-style deck: problem, why now (YC request, scam numbers), demo, how it works on Bolna, traction (families, calls, retention, rupees), market (India's 150M+ people over 60, their children in metros and abroad), competition and why phone-first wins, team, what's next (Scam Shield, hospital partners). A README with architecture, how to run, and the Bolna features used.
6. **Day 16, Oct 31: submit before noon.** Keep the pilot running.
7. **Nov 3 to 7: interview prep.** Practise the YC 10-minute format: one-sentence pitch; who uses it today and how often; what users taught you; why you; biggest risk; what you would do with three months. Know every number cold.
8. **Nov 8 to 20: finale prep.** A live call on stage to a real parent (pre-arranged, with consent) and a recorded backup. For the crowd: "text this number and Parent Line calls your parent in 60 seconds" (needs paid concurrency).

How you know it is working

- Agent: 20 test calls to your own phone pass the awkward-case script; per-turn latency in Bolna's call history stays under about one second.
- Product: by Oct 22, five families get daily calls with WhatsApp summaries; by Oct 29, at least 20 families, 150 completed calls and three paying.

- Submission: the live link talks within 10 seconds; the video has real audio; the deck opens for "Anyone with the link".

Open questions and next steps

Four answers from you change the plan materially; everything else can start today.

Questions

1. Which idea do you commit to? My recommendation is Parent Line with scam-flagging as the headline feature.
2. Team size and skills (frontend, backend, ML, design)? Parent Line is buildable solo.
3. Unfair access: a parent or grandparent to pilot with; a doctor, school, NGO or shop owner who would pilot; a registered company (needed only for inbound numbers).
4. Are you based in Bengaluru? Travel is covered for the top 3 regardless.

Do today

- [ ] Apply on the buildathon page
- [ ] Join the Bolna Builders Slack and request Web Call SDK access and sponsor credits
- [ ] Create Bolna, Sarvam, Deepgram, Cartesia, OpenAI and Vercel accounts; top up Bolna by $10
- [ ] Register interest for Symphony
- [ ] Post the first build-in-public update tagging @bolna_dev
- [ ] Line up the first five pilot families (start with your own)

Unverified items to confirm in Slack

- Exact sponsor credit amounts for buildathon participants
- Whether finalists' Symphony tickets include the $100 Bolna and ₹2,500 Sarvam credits
- Whether Bolna will waive the CIN/GST requirement for a demo inbound number (unlikely; plan without it)
- Who sits on the interview panel and the finale jury

Sources

Pages opened on Oct 15, 2026. Facts not on these pages are marked as my judgement in the text.

- Buildathon page and submission form
- Symphony 2026 and speakers

- Bolna docs: pricing, FAQ, platform concepts, docs index, voice agents index, preferred models, concurrency tiers, buying phone numbers, compliance application, 140/160 numbers, Truecaller verification, making outbound calls, Web Call SDK, web search tool, WhatsApp via AiSensy, testing before calling customers, agent templates, changelog Oct 2026, changelog Sep 2026, developer resources
- Y Combinator Requests for Startups, Fall 2026; Grey Baker, YC; YC GP announcement; Indie Hackers on Dependabot
- TechCrunch on Bolna's seed and YC rejections; YC company page; Jairaj Neve on what was hard at Bolna
- Sponsor pricing: Deepgram, Cartesia, Sarvam pricing and Sarvam credits, Exotel trial, Plivo India calling
- Market: Digital arrest scam; Samarth on NRI parents; YC Voice Agents Hackathon starter; Simple AI launch; O2 Daisy; Khyaal funding

Added for the five more ideas, the critique and the market size (opened Oct 15, 2026):

- Ageing and market: UNFPA India Ageing Report 2023; LASI Wave 1 fact sheet, Elderly in India; MEA population of overseas Indians; Emoha plans; Samarth care plans; Reca; inTouch; JoyCalls launch; Papa Series D; Intuition Robotics funding; Mordor senior living; Coherent geriatric care; LT-EDI elderly Tamil ASR; DPDP Rules notification, PIB; Plivo India voice pricing
- Healthcare ideas: BMJ Open consultation length, via Fierce Healthcare; Kolkata OPD study 2024; EkaScribe; Pype AI pre-seed; Hippocratic AI; ARMMAN Q4 FY25-26 impact report; Noora Health GenAI messaging, Stanford Impact; ICMR-INDIAB coverage and NMJI commentary; adherence market, Growthjockey; HCAH and QMS merger; Fitterfly Series A
- Consumer and developer-tool ideas: ServiceNow India CX 2024, via CRN; ServiceNow 2025, via Storyboard18; Google Hold for Me; Bolna DTMF and event injection; Vapi call features; Synthflow changelog; Regal takeover; Agnost AI, YC

Added for the India voice-agent market section (opened Oct 16, 2026): The Hundred-Buyer Problem; NextMSC figures via Caller Digital; Grand View India AI agents; MarketsandMarkets India AI voice generator; Gnani Series B and Gnani 1M calls a day; GreyLabs, Elevation Capital; ConvoZen, Business Today; SquadStack e-commerce playbook; VoxTurn telecaller cost, Tribune; eCorpIT voice AI costs; TCCCPR 2025 amendment, Bar and Bench; TCCCPR 2026 Third Amendment, IndiaLaw; VoicERA launch, MeitY; Sarlaben, Plivo; Wispr Flow in India, TechCrunch; Tracxn voice AI startups in India

Added for the nutritionist check-in idea (opened Oct 17, 2026): Diet Mojo; WhatsApp Business Calling API, Meta; Chakra on WhatsApp AI voicebots; Bolna Google Sheets tutorial; Accountability in weight-loss programs, Cureus 2024; weekly vs monthly

sessions study; HealthifyMe pricing 2026; HealthifyMe coaches, Entrackr; India personalized nutrition, MarketsandMarkets; Fay Series B, MedCity News; Zoconut, Capterra